Friday, November 13, 2026
Memorial

St. Frances Xavier Cabrini

Virgin, Foundress, Patroness of Immigrants · Feast, November 13



Mother Frances Xavier Cabrini, Portrait photograph, 1880s, author unknown[1]

1. Mother Frances Xavier Cabrini, portrait photograph, 1880s, author unknown; Wikimedia Commons.

✠ The Essentials

- **Origin:** born in Sant'Angelo Lodigiano, Italy.[2]
- **Born:** July 15, 1850.[3]
- **Died:** in Chicago, on December 22, 1917, of malaria, at the Columbus Hospital she had founded.[4] [5]
- **Feast:** November 13, a memorial in the United States.[6]
- **Titles:** foundress of the Missionary Sisters of the Sacred Heart of Jesus; canonized in 1946, the first U.S. citizen to be canonized; Patroness of Immigrants since 1950.[7] [8]

✠ Her Life in Brief

From childhood Maria Francesca Cabrini was drawn to the stories of missionaries and wanted a religious life.[9]

- Her frail health kept existing communities from accepting her. Encouraged by a local bishop, she founded her own order, the Missionary Sisters of the Sacred Heart of Jesus.[10]
- She hoped to take her sisters to China, but Pope Leo XIII told her to go "not to the East, but to the West." In 1889 she and six

2. United States Conference of Catholic Bishops, "Saint Frances Xavier Cabrini, Patroness of Immigrants" (Washington, DC: USCCB, n.d.).
3. Ibid.
4. *Liturgy of the Hours*, Memorial of St. Frances Xavier Cabrini (November 13), biographical note.
5. USCCB, "Saint Frances Xavier Cabrini."
6. *The Roman Missal*, 3rd typical ed., Memorial of St. Frances Xavier Cabrini, Virgin (November 13).
7. USCCB, "Saint Frances Xavier Cabrini."
8. Ibid.
9. Ibid.
10. Ibid.

sisters reached New York City to help the thousands of Italian immigrants there.[11]

- She met poverty and anti-Italian feeling and founded orphanages, catechism classes and schools. Requests came from across the country for schools, hospitals and orphanages.[12] [13]
- She made 24 trans-Atlantic crossings and founded 67 institutions, and became a U.S. citizen in 1909.[14]
- She died on December 22, 1917.[15] Pius XII canonized her in 1946, waiving the usual fifty-year wait, and in 1950 named her universal Patroness of Immigrants.[16]

✠ Famous Excerpt: Pius XII on her canonization

> *"She gathered endangered youth in safe houses, and taught the holy and rightful principles. She consoled the spirit of the imprisoned, giving them the comfort of life eternal… She consoled the sick and the infirm gathered in hospitals, and cared for them assiduously. Especially towards immigrants, who had left their own homes… did she extend a friendly hand, a sheltering refuge, relief and help."*[17]

> Pope Pius XII said this when he canonized her in 1946.[18]

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11. Ibid.
12. Ibid.
13. Ibid.
14. Ibid.
15. Ibid.
16. Ibid.
17. Pius XII, canonization of Frances Xavier Cabrini (July 7, 1946), quoted in USCCB, "Saint Frances Xavier Cabrini, Patroness of Immigrants."
18. Ibid.

✠ 1. Catechesis

Lesson: teach the faith where people actually live. In New York she opened catechism classes along with orphanages and schools for the Italian community.[19] Her sisters helped immigrants stay connected to their faith in unfamiliar surroundings.[20]

Exercise: teach one simple part of the faith to someone younger or newer to it this week, such as the Our Father or the Sign of the Cross.

✠ 2. Apologetics

Objection: "Faith fades when people leave home, and there is little the Church can do about it." Her answer was in deeds: schools, hospitals and orphanages that put the Church's care within reach of immigrants.[21] She did not wait for good conditions. In New York she faced the language barrier, poverty and rampant anti-Italian feeling, and she remained steadfast.[22]

✠ 3. Theology

- **The Sacred Heart:** the order she founded bears the name of the Sacred Heart of Jesus.[23]
- **Seeing Christ in the neighbor:** the Church's Collect for her day asks to "see Christ in all the men and women we meet."[24]

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19. USCCB, "Saint Frances Xavier Cabrini."
20. Ibid.
21. Ibid.
22. Ibid.
23. Ibid.
24. *The Roman Missal*, 3rd typical ed., Memorial of St. Frances Xavier Cabrini, Virgin (November 13), Collect.

- **Missionary obedience:** she had hoped for China and went west on the Pope's word.[25]

✠ 4. Devotional Prayer

Collect, Memorial of St. Frances Xavier Cabrini (Roman Missal, November 13):[26]
God our Father, who called Saint Frances Xavier Cabrini from Italy to serve the immigrants of America, by her example, teach us to have concern for the stranger, the sick, and all those in need, and by her prayers help us to see Christ in all the men and women we meet. Through our Lord Jesus Christ, your Son, who lives and reigns with you in the unity of the Holy Spirit, one God, forever and ever. Amen.

The Memorare, a traditional prayer asking the Virgin Mary's intercession:[27]
Remember, O most gracious Virgin Mary, that never was it known that anyone who fled to thy protection, implored thy help, or sought thy intercession, was left unaided. Inspired by this confidence I fly unto thee, O Virgin of virgins, my Mother. To thee do I come, before thee I stand, sinful and sorrowful. O Mother of the Word Incarnate, despise not my petitions, but in thy mercy hear and answer me. Amen.

Practice: Pray the Collect slowly once today, then name one stranger or person in need you will help this week.

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25. USCCB, "Saint Frances Xavier Cabrini."
26. *Roman Missal*, Nov. 13, Collect.
27. The Memorare, traditional prayer, in USCCB, "Prayers."

✠ Today's Takeaway

Cabrini went where she was sent and served immigrants in the name of Christ.[28] [29]

St. Frances Xavier Cabrini, pray for us.

28. USCCB, "Saint Frances Xavier Cabrini."
29. *Roman Missal*, Nov. 13, Collect.